NewsBank inc.

California Could Change Drinking Water Standards Under New Bill

February 20, 2025 | Newsweek: Web Edition Articles (USA)
Author: Anna Skinner; Senior Writer, General Assignment | Section: Better Planet | 495 Words
OpenURL Link

If a recently introduced California bill becomes law, the state will be able to maintain or strengthen current federal limits for "forever chemicals" in drinking water, even if the Trump administration repeals the Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) decision that established the limits.

Newsweek reached out to the White House by email for comment.

Why It Matters

Assembly Bill 794—titled the California Safe Drinking Water Act: emergency regulations—comes as concerns rise nationwide about the presence of per- and polyfluoroalkyl substances, or PFAS, in products and waterways.

PFAS encompass thousands of human-made chemicals found in everyday items like nonstick cookware, firefighting foams, grease-resistant food wrappers, water-resistant clothing and a multitude of other items. PFAS, known as "forever chemicals" because of the long time they take to break down, can cause harm in large amounts.

What To Know

California Assemblyman Jesse Gabriel, a Democrat, proposed the bill out of fears that current federal limits for certain PFAS in drinking water, which were established by the EPA last year under the Biden administration, could be repealed by the Trump administration.

If it becomes law, the bill will allow the State Water Resources Control Board to set PFAS limits for drinking water that are as or more protective than the EPA's limits in place on January 19, 2025, a day before President Donald Trump took office.

The bill could preserve or strengthen the current limits, even if the Trump administration changes or repeals them.

Within days of taking office, Trump authored a slew of executive orders that had sweeping impacts on government agencies and initiatives. One such initiative was a drafted proposal from the EPA that would limit PFAS in industrial wastewater. Trump withdrew the plan when he issued an executive order to freeze any new federal regulations pending review from the White House.

However, the action didn't affect the limits on six PFAS established by the EPA last year. Gabriel's bill strives to ensure that remains the case for California.

During the breakdown process, PFAS can leach into the soil and the water supply. The chemicals also threaten water when products containing them are dumped onto the ground or into lakes and rivers.

High levels of certain PFAS can cause heightened cholesterol, decreased vaccine response in children, changes in liver enzymes, increased risk of high blood pressure or preeclampsia in pregnant women, decreases in birth weight and an increased risk of kidney or testicular cancer, according to an Agency for Toxic Substances and Disease Registry webpage dedicated to PFAS.

What People Are Saying

California Assemblyman Jesse Gabriel, in a report by The Hill: "Californians shouldn't have to worry that their

drinking water has been contaminated by toxic forever chemicals that are linked to deadly cancers and other serious health harms.

"Unfortunately, we have seen recently efforts by corporate polluters to challenge the federal standards. They're trying to weaken and roll back these protections that are so essential for our communities."

What Happens Next

The bill was introduced on Tuesday and is pending approval. A majority vote is required to pass the bill through the Assembly.

© 2025 NEWSWEEK DIGITAL LLC

- **Citation (apa Style)**
  Skinner, A. (2025, February 20). California Could Change Drinking Water Standards Under New Bill.*Newsweek: Web Edition Articles (USA)*. Available from NewsBank: Access World News – Historical and Current: https://infoweb.newsbank.com/apps/news/document-view?p=WORLDNEWS&docref=news/1A313F3B37DC23F0.